Draft: pending clinical review

Low iron and anaemia

How to take your iron tablets so they work, and when to get help

The 5 things to remember

- Iron tablets work best on an **empty stomach** with water or orange juice.
- Keep **tea, coffee, milk and antacids** at least 2 hours away from your iron.
- Black or dark green stool is **normal** on iron.
- Keep taking iron for about **3 months after** your blood count is normal.
- Keep iron tablets **away from children**: an overdose is dangerous.

What is iron deficiency anaemia?

Your body uses iron to make haemoglobin, the part of the blood that carries oxygen. When iron runs low, you make less haemoglobin. This is called anaemia.

You may feel tired, short of breath, dizzy, or cold. Some people get headaches, hair fall, brittle nails, or a craving to chew ice. Some people feel nothing at all.

Why does it happen?

- Heavy or long periods.
- Pregnancy and breastfeeding.
- Not enough iron in food.
- Slow blood loss from the stomach or bowel.
- Problems absorbing iron, such as coeliac disease.

Your doctor will look for the cause, not just treat the low number.

Before you start iron

- In Saudi Arabia, **thalassaemia trait** is common. It can look like low iron on a blood count.
- Only take iron if a blood test (ferritin) shows your iron is low.
- If you had premarital screening, tell your doctor the result.

How do I take my iron tablets?

- Take them as your doctor prescribed: **once a day or every other day**. Every other day works well for many people and is often easier on the stomach.
- Take them **1 hour before a meal**, with water or orange juice. Vitamin C helps your body take in iron.
- If they upset your stomach, take them with a small meal. Taking them with food is better than stopping.
- Leave **2 hours** between your iron and tea, coffee (including Arabic coffee), milk, calcium tablets, or antacids.
- Constipation? Drink more water and eat more fibre. Tell your doctor if it continues: another type of iron may suit you better.

How long will I take iron?

- Your doctor will usually check your blood again after about **4 weeks**.
- Haemoglobin rises first. Your iron stores fill up more slowly.
- Keep taking iron for about **3 months after** your haemoglobin is back to normal.

Which foods have iron?

Foods with iron the body absorbs well	Plant foods with iron
Red meat, liver (avoid liver if pregnant)	Lentils, chickpeas, beans (ful)
Chicken, turkey	Dark green leafy vegetables
Fish and seafood	Fortified breakfast cereals
	Dates, raisins and dried apricots (a little)

Eat plant iron with vitamin C: lemon, orange, tomato or peppers. Food alone usually cannot fix anaemia. You still need the tablets.

Get help now; call 997 or go to the emergency department if you have:

- Chest pain, severe shortness of breath, or fainting.
- Vomiting blood.
- Black, sticky, tar-like stool with dizziness. (Stool from iron is dark but formed, and you feel well.)
- Very heavy bleeding that soaks a pad every hour.

See your doctor soon if:

- You feel no better after 4 weeks.
- Side effects stop you taking the tablets.
- Your periods are still very heavy.
- You lose weight without trying, or your bowel habit changes.

My plan

My iron tablet, dose and how often: _____

My next blood test: _____

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This leaflet gives general information. It does not replace advice from your own doctor, who knows your health. Bring it to your next visit and ask about anything that is unclear. Written with AI assistance, checked by the medical editor, and still under review with colleagues.

Last updated: October 2026 · **Next review:** October 2027, or sooner if guidance changes

Sources:

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